World Health Organization
African Region

MEC 2026 | DAY 2 | PAPER MEC-09 | FOR DECISION

MEAL implementation policies

Seven policies that give effect to the WHO AFRO Performance Intelligence Operating System

Friday 20 November 2026, Blocks A, B and C | Djoué, Brazzaville, and online | For decision

Draft of 4 November 2026 for TWG review. Parameters such as deadlines, response times and thresholds not set by the Framework are proposals, shown as such in the decision options.

What the MEC is asked to decide

The MEC is asked to take one decision on each of the seven policies: **adopt**, **adopt with amendments** or **refer back** to the TWG with a deadline. The Regional Director confirms each decision at the close of the meeting.

Adopted policies take effect on 1 January 2027. The costed MEAL implementation roadmap (paper MEC-10) is revised in line with the decisions by 27 November 2026.

	Policy	Recommended option
Block A. Know where we stand, 09:05–10:05		
P1	**Minimum MEAL Package and maturity baseline** Every Country Office reaches and keeps the Minimum MEAL Package floor, establishes its maturity baseline through a Learning Lab by June 2028 and turns it into a costed Country MEAL Development Plan endorsed by the WR.	Mandatory for all Country Offices, in three waves, with a self-assessment by March 2027
P2	**Performance evidence standard** Every P/S rating rests on evidence that can be checked: completion and contribution cite their evidence, the reliability of each figure is stated, financial figures come from corporate systems, and MSC verifies a sample each cycle.	Standard as proposed, for Country Offices and Regional Office budget centres from January 2027
Block B. Fund and staff MEAL, 10:20–11:20		
P3	**MEAL financing gateway of 3%** At least 3% of each budget centre's financed workplan budget goes to MEAL capabilities: visible in the workplan, tracked in expenditure and protected from reprogramming. New proposals budget MEAL at 3% or more.	3% of financed budget, all funding sources, with the proposal rule
P4	**MEAL function and competencies** Every Country Office designates a MEAL focal point with terms of reference, protected time and a reporting line to the WR; MEAL competencies are verified, and focal points are certified through the Performance Intelligence Academy by March 2028.	As proposed, with at least 50% protected time
Block C. Use evidence for decisions, 11:20–12:35		
P5	**Country-led evaluation and management response** Each Country Office keeps a costed evaluation plan, commissions at least one substantive evaluation per biennium from non-earmarked funds, leads CCS evaluations with national evaluators, and answers every evaluation with a management response tracked to completion.	Plan and management response mandatory; roster mandatory for CCS evaluations, exceptions approved by DPM
P6	**Decision follow-up and Regional Office support standard** Every decision records its evidence, root cause, owner, deadline and how completion will be verified; actions close only with verification; overdue actions are escalated; lessons are recorded and shared; Regional Office support requests are acknowledged within 5 working days and answered with an agreed plan within 20.	As proposed
P7	**Burden- and equity-informed operational planning** Each Country Office submits a two-page alignment profile with its 2028–2029 workplans, showing how its P/S, funding and workforce match national priorities, the burden of disease and the populations left behind; the Regional Office reviews it before approving the workplan.	Profile mandatory for all Country Offices

Where the policies come from

The Performance Intelligence Operating System (the Framework) sets the architecture of MEAL in the Region: the Decision Intelligence Cycle, four pillars and twelve domains of capability, the Minimum MEAL Package with its 3% financing gateway, the Maturity Assessment, the Country MEAL Development Plan and the Digital Performance Intelligence Platform.

The Framework says what a functioning system requires. These policies make those requirements binding: what must happen, by when, who is accountable and how compliance is checked. They add no new architecture. Where the Framework leaves a parameter open, such as a deadline, a response time or a threshold, the policy proposes one. Every proposal is listed in the table of proposed parameters at the end of this paper, so the MEC can amend any of them without reopening the policy.

Policy	Framework domains	Framework references
P1 Minimum MEAL Package and maturity baseline	All twelve domains at the floor (Annex C), strengthened in the Framework's order of priority (Part XIV.2)	Framework Parts VII, VIII and XIII; Annexes A, B, C and D; Annex G, Modules 5, 6 and 12
P2 Performance evidence standard	D4 Data systems, D5 Monitoring, D7 Analytics	Framework Parts VI and X.1; Annex C, Domains 4 and 5; Annex E; Annex G, Modules 1, 2 and 4; Annexes H and J (not in this package)
P3 MEAL financing gateway of 3%	D3 MEAL financing (the gateway of the Minimum MEAL Package)	Framework Part VII.2; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 3.1 to 3.4; Annex B, Section B8; Annex C, Section C4; Annex I (not in this package)
P4 MEAL function and competencies	D11 Human capacity; D1 Governance (Sub-dimension 1.2)	Framework Parts XI and XII; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 1.2 and 11.1 to 11.4; Annex C, Domains 1 and 11; Annex M (not in this package)
P5 Country-led evaluation and management response	D6 Evaluation; D3 (Sub-dimension 3.2); D10 Accountability	Framework Parts II.4 and X.2; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 3.2, 6.1 to 6.4, 10.1 and 11.4; Annex C, Domain 6 and Section C6; Annex G, Module 9
P6 Decision follow-up and Regional Office support standard	D8 Decision-making; D9 Learning; D10 Accountability	Framework Parts III.4, X.4 and XI.2; Annex B, Section B5; Annex C, Domains 8 and 9; Annex E; Annex G, Modules 7, 8 and 10; Annex J (not in this package)
P7 Burden- and equity-informed operational planning	D2 Results architecture; D7 Analytics; D12 Gender and equity	Framework Parts I.4, II.2 and X.3; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 2.1, 2.4, 7.3 and 12.1; Annex C, Domains 2 and 12; Annex F, Section F1

Domains: D1 Governance, D2 Results architecture, D3 MEAL financing, D4 Data systems, D5 Monitoring, D6 Evaluation, D7 Analytics, D8 Decision-making, D9 Learning, D10 Accountability, D11 Human capacity, D12 Gender and equity. D9 Learning is covered through the Minimum MEAL Package floor in P1.

Principles for all seven policies

- **Function, not form.** A requirement is met when it works, not when a document exists. Verification looks for functional and behavioural evidence; documents alone never suffice. Symbolic compliance is recorded as not met (Annex C, Sections C5 and C6).
- **Authority stays where it is.** The policies create no parallel chain of command. The WHO Representative remains accountable for MEAL in the office; programme leads remain responsible for delivery (Framework, Parts I.5 and XI.3).
- **Non-punitive, never a ranking.** Maturity and compliance results direct support. The heat map is a diagnostic, not a league table. Persistent gaps without progress lead to a graduated management response, not a sanction (Framework, Part XI.4).
- **One evidence base, entered once.** Data are entered once on the Digital Performance Intelligence Platform (Annex G) and reused for the monthly review, the Semi-Annual Monitoring cycles (SAM1 and SAM2), the MTR and EOB reporting. Redundant reporting routines are consolidated (Framework, Parts IX and XIV.2). The

policies propose that the platform used for SAM1 2026 serves as the first phase of the platform until Annex G is implemented.

- **Core first, differentiated by context.** Every office secures the MEAL Core before advancing, in the Framework's order of priority: governance first, then P/S tracking and data quality, then the decision log and action tracker alongside financing and human capacity (Part XIV.2). Emergency contexts may need an adjusted sequence; the policies propose that the DPM agrees any adjustment and that the floor itself is not lowered.

Scope, follow-up and review

Scope	The Framework uses "Budget Centre" for the 47 Country Offices. In these policies, as in SAM1, "budget centre" covers the 47 Country Offices and the six Regional Office budget centres, 53 in all, and "Country Office" is used where a provision applies to the 47 only. The policies apply to the 47 Country Offices. The six Regional Office budget centres apply P2, P3 and P6 to their own products and services and operations, and complete the Annex C self-assessment under P1. The Regional Office clusters, the MSC Unit and the DPM carry the support and oversight duties set out in each policy. Terms are used as defined in Annex E.
When an office stays below a requirement	The Framework's graduated response applies to persistent low maturity without progress: a formal management discussion, a revised Country MEAL Development Plan, a targeted support plan and, where necessary, escalation to the MEC or the Regional Programme Meeting (Part XI.4). The policies propose that "persistent" means no progress across two consecutive annual reviews, and that the DPM holds the management discussion.
Planning calendar	The 2028–2029 workplans are prepared in the 2027 planning cycle. Anything that is ready only after they are approved, such as a development plan endorsed in 2028, enters at the first workplan revision.
Review of the policies	MSC reports to the MEC each year on the implementation of the seven policies, starting at MEC 2027. The policies are reviewed at MEC 2028, after the baseline maturity assessments are complete. Where a policy relies on an instrument that the Framework lists but that is not part of this package (Annexes H to M), it states the interim rule that applies until the instrument is issued.

Changes since the concept note

- P1 was called "Performance Intelligence entry gate" in the concept note. The Framework reserves "entry gate" for products and services, so P1 is now named after what it makes binding: the Minimum MEAL Package and the maturity baseline.
- P5 covered country-led CCS evaluations only. It now covers the Framework's evaluation requirements as a whole: evaluation plans, a self-commissioned evaluation each biennium and tracked management responses, with the CCS provision kept.
- P7 now includes the Framework's equity requirement (Domain 12) alongside the burden of disease.
- P6 now also covers learning from follow-through (Domain 9), part of the MEAL Core.

P1. Minimum MEAL Package and maturity baseline

> **The policy in brief**
>
> Every Country Office reaches and keeps the Minimum MEAL Package floor, establishes its maturity baseline through a Learning Lab by June 2028 and turns it into a costed Country MEAL Development Plan endorsed by the WR.

Why this policy

The Minimum MEAL Package is the floor below which a Country Office cannot credibly claim that evidence informs its decisions. The Framework sets the floor at Level 3 (Developing) and builds every other instrument on it: the Country MEAL Development Plan closes gaps to the floor first, the heat map shows where support is needed, and the re-assessment tracks progress.

None of this works until each office knows where it stands. Today the Region has a measured baseline for four pilot offices only, so support cannot be targeted and development plans have no diagnosis to start from.

What the evidence shows

- A measured MEAL maturity baseline exists in **4 of 47** Country Offices (Performance Intelligence pilots, 2026; paper MEC-08).
- Two floor disciplines are not yet visible in SAM1 2026: **1 of 1,336** P/S assessments cites an evidence source (Domain 5), and the decision log records no verification of completion, with **91 of 970** entries overdue at export (Domain 8).

Scope

The 47 Country Offices. The six Regional Office budget centres complete the Annex C self-assessment for their own operations in 2027.

The policy

1. **The Minimum MEAL Package is mandatory.** Every Country Office reaches at least Level 3 (Developing) against the minimum requirements of Annex C, the master reference for all twelve domains, starting with the seven essential domains summarized in Part VII.1, and keeps it. The 3% financing requirement (Domain 3) is the gateway: an office below it does not meet the Package, whatever its other results (see P3).
2. **Self-assessment by 31 March 2027.** Each office completes the Annex C self-assessment checklist, with the evidence for each requirement. MSC consolidates the results into a first regional view of the floor and uses it to schedule the Learning Labs.
3. **A maturity baseline in three waves.** Each office establishes its baseline against the four pillars, twelve domains and 48 sub-dimensions (Annex A) through a facilitated Learning Lab: wave 1 from January to June 2027, wave 2 from July to December 2027 and wave 3 from January to June 2028. MSC sets the order with the clusters, starting with offices whose self-assessment shows the largest gaps and offices preparing a new CCS. The four pilot offices confirm their 2026 baseline against the final scale in wave 1.
4. **Scores rest on evidence.** Offices score themselves against the descriptors of Annex D and MSC validates the scores for consistency across offices. A level is awarded only when its criteria are met and supported by verifiable evidence; where evidence is ambiguous, the lower level applies. Documentary evidence alone never meets a requirement (Annex C, Section C5).
5. **A development plan within eight weeks.** Within eight weeks of its validated baseline, each office prepares its Country MEAL Development Plan on the Annex B template: priority gaps, root causes, target levels, actions, owners, costs and funding sources. Closing gaps to the floor comes before any other improvement. The WR endorses the plan as a resource commitment; MSC validates it for the Region as a commitment to support (Annex B, Template Section 10).

6. **The plan lives in the workplan.** Each office enters the actions that close the gaps found in its self-assessment in its 2028–2029 workplan. The full development plan enters the SPM and the workplan once endorsed: at workplan preparation for offices assessed in wave 1, and at the first workplan revision of 2028 for waves 2 and 3. Progress is reviewed monthly in the WR-led review, against milestones each quarter, alongside each SAM cycle and in full once a year (Annex B, Section B9).
7. **Annual check, re-assessment every two years.** Package status is reviewed each year in step with the SAM cycle (Annex C, Section C11). The full maturity assessment is repeated two years after the baseline.
8. **Results direct support.** Validated scores feed the Regional Maturity Heat Map, which targets support and is never used to rank offices. An office below the floor receives targeted support and an accelerated plan.

Who does what

WHO Representative	Accountable for reaching and keeping the floor; endorses the development plan and chairs its monthly review.
MEAL focal point	Leads the self-assessment, assembles the evidence and coordinates the plan and its tracking.
Programme leads	Meet the floor in their areas, in particular P/S monitoring and decision follow-up.
MSC Unit	Schedules the waves, facilitates Learning Labs, validates scores and development plans, maintains the heat map and reports to the DPM and the MEC.
Regional Office clusters	Provide the support committed in validated plans; join Learning Labs in their technical areas.

Timeline

When	Milestone
20 Nov 2026	Policy adopted by the MEC
31 Mar 2027	Annex C self-assessment completed by all 47 Country Offices
Jan–Jun 2027	Wave 1 Learning Labs, including the four pilot offices
Jul–Dec 2027	Wave 2 Learning Labs; first heat map at MEC 2027
Jan–Jun 2028	Wave 3 Learning Labs; all baselines validated
31 Aug 2028	All 47 development plans endorsed and in the workplans

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
Country Offices with a validated maturity baseline	4 of 47 pilots, to be confirmed in wave 1	47 by 30 June 2028
Country Offices with a WR-endorsed development plan in the workplan	Not yet measured	47 by 31 August 2028
Country Offices meeting the floor in every domain	First, unvalidated reading from the 2027 self-assessment	Rising at each annual review; target set by MEC 2028 from the validated baselines

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**Mandatory for all Country Offices in three waves, with the self-assessment by March 2027**	Every office has a validated baseline and plan by mid-2028, at a pace MSC and the facilitator pool can sustain.

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
B	Mandatory in two waves, with all baselines by December 2027	All plans endorsed by early 2028, a few months sooner; facilitation needs roughly double in 2027.
C	Self-assessment only; Learning Labs on request	Lowest cost, but no validated baseline, no reliable heat map and development plans without a diagnosis.

Resources

Learning Lab facilitation, travel and the platform modules for the assessment and development plan. Costed in paper MEC-10.

The MEC is asked to

Adopt the Minimum MEAL Package as the mandatory floor for all Country Offices and the three-wave baseline schedule (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts VII, VIII and XIII; Annexes A, B, C and D; Annex G, Modules 5, 6 and 12. Domains: All twelve domains at the floor (Annex C), strengthened in the Framework's order of priority (Part XIV.2).

P2. Performance evidence standard

The policy in brief

Every P/S rating rests on evidence that can be checked: completion and contribution cite their evidence, the reliability of each figure is stated, financial figures come from corporate systems, and MSC verifies a sample each cycle.

Why this policy

Products and services are the operational entry gate of the system: what WHO directly delivers, and the level at which performance can be managed most directly. Every decision about delivery, and every account of results given to Member States, inherits the quality of the P/S ratings beneath it.

SAM1 2026 produced ratings for 1,336 priority P/S, but almost none can be traced to evidence. This policy sets the standard each rating must meet before it is signed off.

What the evidence shows

- **1 of 1,336** P/S assessments cites an evidence source, and that entry is a placeholder.
- **255 of 1,276** rated figures (20%) are estimated or unavailable rather than confirmed.
- **105** country P/S rated on track reported less than 30% progress at the September 2026 export, eight and a half months into the 24-month biennium; **29** P/S rated on track carry an at-risk or off-track risk flag.
- **64 of 459** P/S with a utilisation rate report spending more than 150% of budget; planned cost is missing for 607 P/S.

Scope

All P/S assessments of the 47 Country Offices and the six Regional Office budget centres in SAM, the MTR and EOB reporting, and the P/S data used in the monthly WR-led review.

The policy

1. **Six metrics.** P/S performance is assessed against the six metrics of the Framework: delivery completion, timeliness, quality, reach or coverage, utilization and contribution to output (Framework, Part VI.3). Until Annex H sets the data fields, the SAM1 assessment form applies, with the fields this policy adds.
2. **Ratings cite their evidence.** A rating of “completed” cites the evidence that the deliverable exists, such as the document, dataset or event record. A rating of “strong contribution” cites the evidence that the P/S advanced its output, such as use by the intended audience, an observed change or confirmation by the government or a partner. A rating without cited evidence is recorded as unverified and is not counted as completed or strong in regional reports.
3. **Reliability is stated.** Every figure is marked confirmed, estimated or unavailable. An estimate states its basis.
4. **Status and progress agree.** Where the delivery status, the progress reported and the risk flag point in different directions, the office explains the difference or corrects the rating before sign-off. The platform flags these cases.
5. **Financial figures come from corporate systems.** Planned cost, funded amount and expenditure are taken from the SPM and GSM, not entered by hand. Until the platform draws on them directly (Annex G, Phase 3), MSC supplies the extract for each cycle. Utilisation above 150% is reviewed with the budget and finance officer before sign-off.
6. **Data quality assurance.** Each office documents the sources of its decision-critical indicators and runs a data quality assessment on them at least once a year, recording their reliability (Annex C, Domain 4).
7. **Monthly use.** P/S delivery is reviewed in the monthly WR-led performance and learning review, at cluster level each quarter, and in SAM, the MTR and EOB reporting (Framework, Part VI.4).
8. **Verification sample.** Each cycle, MSC checks a random sample of 10% of the “completed” and “strong contribution” ratings across the Region against the cited evidence, covering every budget centre at least once a

year, and reports the share confirmed. Ratings not confirmed are returned for correction before regional consolidation. The WR's sign-off certifies that the office's ratings rest on the evidence cited.

Who does what

Programme leads	Rate their P/S and cite the evidence.
MEAL focal point	Checks evidence and consistency before sign-off; runs the annual data quality assessment.
WHO Representative or budget centre director	Signs off the ratings, certifying the evidence; uses P/S data in the monthly review.
MSC Unit	Issues the evidence guidance; supplies the SPM and GSM extracts; runs the verification sample and reports its results.
Regional Office clusters	Review the P/S in their area each quarter.

Timeline

When	Milestone
1 Jan 2027	Standard applies to every assessment
31 Mar 2027	Evidence guidance with examples by type of P/S; evidence and consistency fields on the platform
SAM1 2027	First cycle with pre-filled financial figures and the verification sample
31 Dec 2027	Every office has run one data quality assessment
MEC 2027	First report on verification results

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
"Completed" and "strong contribution" ratings citing evidence	0% (SAM1 2026)	At least 90% in SAM1 2027; 100% from 2028
Rated figures that are confirmed	80% (1,021 of 1,276)	90% by 2028
Sampled ratings confirmed by verification	Not yet measured	At least 90%
Offices with an annual data quality assessment	Not yet measured	47 by 31 December 2027

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**Standard as proposed, for Country Offices and Regional Office budget centres from January 2027**	Ratings reported for the 2026–2027 biennium can be checked; adds a verification workload for MSC each cycle.
B	Evidence required for "completed" only; contribution evidence from 2028	Lighter start, but contribution claims in the end-of-biennium report stay unverifiable.
C	Guidance only, without the verification sample	No added cost, but no assurance on the figures reported to Member States.

Resources

MSC time for the verification sample each cycle and platform changes for the evidence and consistency fields. Costed in paper MEC-10.

The MEC is asked to

Adopt the performance evidence standard for all budget centres from 1 January 2027 (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts VI and X.1; Annex C, Domains 4 and 5; Annex E; Annex G, Modules 1, 2 and 4; Annexes H and J (not in this package). Domains: D4 Data systems, D5 Monitoring, D7 Analytics.

P3. MEAL financing gateway of 3%

The policy in brief

At least 3% of each budget centre's financed workplan budget goes to MEAL capabilities: visible in the workplan, tracked in expenditure and protected from reprogramming. New proposals budget MEAL at 3% or more.

Why this policy

Without financing, MEAL remains rhetorical. The Framework makes financing the gateway of the Minimum MEAL Package: an office that does not allocate and protect at least 3% of its resources for MEAL capabilities does not meet the floor, however well its other domains perform.

The threshold follows the Framework's reasoning: WHO governing bodies have recognized evaluation alone as warranting about 1% of resources, so 3% is a reasonable minimum for the whole system of monitoring, data, evaluation, analytics, learning, digital tools and capacity. Today MEAL is planned close to that level but financed far below it.

What the evidence shows

- In the 2026–2027 workplans, MEAL is **4.21% of planned costs** but **1.35% of financed costs**: **US$ 39.7 million** of MEAL is planned but not financed (provisional; paper MEC-08).
- MEAL cannot be tracked consistently today: workplans carry no common MEAL marker, so the figures above had to be reconstructed by analysis.

Scope

The workplans of the 47 Country Offices and the six Regional Office budget centres, all funding sources, and every proposal or award budget prepared by them.

The policy

1. **The gateway.** Each budget centre allocates at least 3% of its resources to MEAL capabilities. The Framework measures the 3% against programme resources and leaves the numerator, denominator, eligible costs and exclusions to Annex I. Until Annex I is issued, the MEC sets an interim rule (see options). The recommended rule measures the 3% against the financed workplan budget, meaning the funds available to the workplan as recorded in the corporate systems, and uses the eligible-cost list of Annex C, Section C4. Annex I, when issued, confirms or replaces the interim rule.
2. **What counts.** MEAL staffing, data management, P/S tracking and monitoring operations, data quality assessment and field verification, evaluations and strategic studies, analytics, dashboards and platform use, learning reviews and knowledge management, capacity strengthening, and accountability and feedback mechanisms. Ordinary programme costs are not reclassified as MEAL unless they demonstrably build MEAL capability.
3. **Visible.** Each workplan shows the MEAL allocation with a common MEAL marker in the SPM. For 2027, each budget centre records its current MEAL allocation with the marker by 31 March 2027; from the 2028–2029 workplans, the allocation is planned at 3% or more.
4. **Tracked.** Expenditure against the MEAL allocation is drawn from GSM and reported at each SAM cycle.
5. **Ring-fenced.** The MEAL allocation is ring-fenced from reprogramming (Annex A, 3.1). It may be moved between MEAL uses with the WR's documented approval, reported to MSC, but not to other purposes. A fall below 3% is a gateway failure: it raises the automatic gap flag of Annex C and is reported to the DPM.
6. **First calls on the 3%.** The allocation funds, first, the gaps to the floor in the office's development plan; a non-earmarked evaluation budget sufficient for at least one substantive evaluation per biennium (Annex A, 3.2; see P5); and data quality assessment and field monitoring (Annex A, 3.3).

7. **New proposals.** From 1 January 2027, every proposal and award budget includes MEAL costs of at least 3%, unless the donor's rules set otherwise. Exceptions are recorded with the reason.
8. **Transition and check.** A budget centre below 3% sets out in its development plan how it will reach the gateway in the 2028–2029 workplans. The gateway is checked at each annual Package review; failure raises the automatic gap flag of Annex C.

Who does what

WHO Representative or budget centre director	Accountable for the allocation and its ring-fencing; approves moves between MEAL uses.
Programme leads and external relations officers	Budget MEAL costs in workplans, proposals and award budgets.
Budget and finance officers	Apply the MEAL marker and extract expenditure from GSM.
MEAL focal point	Tracks the allocation and its use; reports at each SAM cycle.
MSC Unit and DPM	MSC issues the methodology and tracks MEAL financing across the Region; the DPM reports it to the MEC and acts on reductions below 3%.

Timeline

When	Milestone
1 Jan 2027	Proposal rule applies
31 Mar 2027	MEAL marker applied; current MEAL allocation recorded for every budget centre
SAM1 2027	First report of MEAL allocation and expenditure by budget centre
2027 planning cycle	MEAL planned at 3% or more in all 2028–2029 workplans
MEC 2027	Regional MEAL financing report

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
MEAL share of financed workplan budget, Region	1.35% (provisional)	At least 3% in the 2028–2029 workplans
Budget centres at or above 3%	Not yet measured	All 53 in the 2028–2029 workplans
Proposals submitted with MEAL at 3% or more	Not yet measured	100% from 2027, exceptions recorded

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**Interim rule: 3% of financed budget, all funding sources, with the proposal rule**	Protects MEAL where money actually arrives; most budget centres must raise their financed MEAL share, about 1.35% across the Region today.
B	3% of planned cost	Already met on paper (4.21%), but leaves MEAL unfunded wherever plans are unfunded.
C	Interim rule: 3% of financed base budget only; emergency and polio funds follow the MEAL rules of their own appeals and plans	A smaller amount to find, but leaves the largest programmes without MEAL protected by this policy.

Resources

No new money: the policy re-directs 3% of financed budgets to MEAL. The proposal rule raises new MEAL funding over time.

> **The MEC is asked to**
>
> Adopt the 3% gateway, with the interim rule of 3% of financed budgets for all funding sources and the proposal rule (option A), until Annex I is issued.

Framework references: Framework Part VII.2; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 3.1 to 3.4; Annex B, Section B8; Annex C, Section C4; Annex I (not in this package). Domains: D3 MEAL financing (the gateway of the Minimum MEAL Package).

P4. MEAL function and competencies

The policy in brief

Every Country Office designates a MEAL focal point with terms of reference, protected time and a reporting line to the WR; MEAL competencies are verified, and focal points are certified through the Performance Intelligence Academy by March 2028.

Why this policy

Tools do not use themselves. The Framework's test of a mature system is that it keeps working when staff change, and that depends on people who own the function, have the time to do it and can interpret evidence, not only compile it.

Today MEAL is often a fractional add-on to a programme role, and competence is assumed from job titles. This policy sets the minimum the Framework requires: an identified focal point, a clear role, verified skills and continuity.

What the evidence shows

- Focal point arrangements differ from office to office in title, time and reporting line (TWG review, 2026).
- SAM1 2026 points to gaps in interpretation and verification rather than data collection: **1 of 1,336** assessments cites an evidence source, and one rated figure in five is estimated or unavailable.
- Staffing is under pressure: in July 2026, **46 of 53** budget centres had less than 75% of their staff costs funded, which leaves MEAL roles exposed.

Scope

The 47 Country Offices, the Regional Office clusters and the MSC Unit.

The policy

1. **A named focal point.** By 31 January 2027, each WR designates a MEAL focal point by name, with terms of reference based on the MSC template. The terms set out the responsibilities of Annex C (Domains 1 and 11), the protected time and the reporting line to the WR on MEAL matters.
2. **Protected time.** The share of working time protected for MEAL is written into the terms of reference and the focal point's performance objectives. The MEC sets the minimum (see options).
3. **Proportionate coverage.** The office's MEAL structure is proportionate to its portfolio (Annex A, 11.1). The development plan sets it out, including the MEAL responsibilities of programme leads.
4. **Verified competencies.** MEAL competencies are defined in the competency framework of the Performance Intelligence Academy (Annex M) and verified, not assumed from job titles (Annex A, 11.2). Until Annex M is issued, the competency framework of the MEAL Competency Development Programme applies. Recruitment to MEAL roles uses them.
5. **Certification by March 2028.** Focal points complete the core track of the Performance Intelligence Academy, the MEAL Competency Development Programme, and are certified by 31 March 2028. WRs and programme leads take part in the leadership orientation on the Framework (Annex F) in 2027.
6. **Continuity.** Before a focal point leaves, a handover note covers the development plan, the decision log and the data sources. The WR designates an interim focal point within 30 days.
7. **A regional network.** Focal points belong to the Regional MEAL Practitioners Network, facilitated by MSC, which also provides the pool of Learning Lab facilitators.
8. **Regional Office focal points.** Each Regional Office cluster names a MEAL focal point who supports Country Offices in its area and handles their MEAL support requests (see P6).

Who does what

WHO Representative	Designates the focal point, protects the time and keeps the role filled.

MEAL focal point	Carries the responsibilities in the terms of reference; completes certification.
Human resources	Reflects MEAL roles and competencies in post descriptions, recruitment and performance objectives.
MSC Unit	Issues the terms of reference template; runs the Academy, certification and the network.
Regional Office clusters	Name a cluster MEAL focal point; release staff for the facilitator pool.

Timeline

When	Milestone
31 Jan 2027	Focal points designated with terms of reference in all 47 offices; cluster focal points named
From Q2 2027	Academy core track in cohorts aligned with the Learning Lab waves
31 Dec 2027	Competencies of all focal points verified
31 Mar 2028	All focal points certified

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
Country Offices with a designated focal point and terms of reference	Not yet measured	47 by 31 January 2027
Focal points certified	Not yet measured	100% by 31 March 2028
Focal point vacancies covered within 30 days	Not yet measured	100%

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**As proposed, with at least 50% of the focal point's time protected for MEAL**	A real role in every office; programme work shifts to others in small offices.
B	Designation and terms of reference only; time and certification left to each WR	Least disruption, but MEAL stays an add-on in most offices.
C	A dedicated MEAL officer post in offices above a budget threshold set by the DPM, option A elsewhere	Strongest capacity; requires posts in the 2028–2029 workforce plans, funded within P3.

Resources

Academy delivery and certification by MSC; staff time. Posts under option C are funded within the 3% of P3.

> **The MEC is asked to**
>
> Adopt the MEAL function and competency requirements with at least 50% protected time (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts XI and XII; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 1.2 and 11.1 to 11.4; Annex C, Domains 1 and 11; Annex M (not in this package). Domains: D11 Human capacity; D1 Governance (Sub-dimension 1.2).

P5. Country-led evaluation and management response

The policy in brief

Each Country Office keeps a costed evaluation plan, commissions at least one substantive evaluation per biennium from non-earmarked funds, leads CCS evaluations with national evaluators, and answers every evaluation with a management response tracked to completion.

Why this policy

Monitoring shows what is happening; evaluation explains why, and tests the assumptions on which programmes rest. The Framework treats evaluation as a managed function whose value lies in the management response: findings must change planning and resources rather than rest on a shelf.

Country-led evaluation also serves WHO's accountability to Member States and its mandate to build national capacity: evaluations of the Country Cooperation Strategy belong to both WHO and the government.

What the evidence shows

- CCS evaluations are commissioned case by case and no regional roster of national evaluators exists (TWG review, 2026).
- The Framework names "an evaluation completed but its recommendations ignored" as a form of symbolic compliance (Annex C, Section C6); responses are not tracked in a common registry today.

Scope

The 47 Country Offices; the MSC Unit for the roster, quality assurance and the evaluation registry.

The policy

1. **An evaluation plan.** Each office keeps a costed evaluation plan for the biennium, set by risk and priority (Annex A, 6.1), recorded in the evaluation registry (Annex G, Module 9; until the module is in place, MSC keeps an interim registry) and included in its development plan and workplan.
2. **One self-commissioned evaluation per biennium.** From the 2028–2029 biennium, each office commissions at least one substantive evaluation per biennium on a question it chooses, financed from non-earmarked funds within its MEAL allocation (Annex A, 3.2; see P3). Strategic studies come in addition. Evaluations already planned for 2026–2027 continue under the plan recorded in 2027.
3. **Country-led CCS evaluations.** From 1 July 2027, CCS evaluations are led jointly with the national authorities and conducted by national evaluators drawn from a pre-qualified regional roster, with quality assurance by the Regional Office. The DPM approves any exception.
4. **A regional roster.** MSC establishes the roster by 30 June 2027 through an open call, with criteria for competence and independence, and renews it every two years.
5. **Credible standards.** Evaluations follow the norms and standards of WHO's evaluation function, with appropriate independence (Annex A, 6.2).
6. **A management response within 60 days.** The WR signs a management response within 60 days of the final report, stating for each recommendation whether it is accepted, and the action, owner and deadline.
7. **Tracked to completion.** Management-response actions are entered in the action tracker and verified like any other decision (see P6). Their status is reviewed in the monthly WR-led review and reported to the MEC each year.

Who does what

WHO Representative	Commissions evaluations, co-leads CCS evaluations with the government and signs the management response.

MEAL focal point	Keeps the plan and the registry entries; tracks management-response actions.
Programme leads	Carry out the actions accepted in management responses.
National authorities	Co-lead CCS evaluations and take part in the response.
MSC Unit and DPM	MSC runs the roster, quality assurance and the registry and reports to the MEC; the DPM approves exceptions.

Timeline

When	Milestone
31 Mar 2027	Templates for the evaluation plan and management response issued; interim registry opened by MSC
30 Jun 2027	Evaluation plans for 2027 recorded; regional roster established
1 Jul 2027	Country-led rule applies to new CCS evaluations
2027 planning cycle	Costed 2028–2029 evaluation plans in the workplans
MEC 2027	First report on evaluations and management responses

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
Country Offices with a costed evaluation plan in the registry	Not yet measured	47 by 30 June 2027
Evaluations with a management response within 60 days	Not yet measured	100%
Management-response actions completed by their deadline	Not yet measured	At least 80%
CCS evaluations conducted by national evaluators from the roster	No roster	All new CCS evaluations from July 2027

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**Plan and management response mandatory; roster mandatory for CCS evaluations, exceptions approved by the DPM**	Builds national evaluation capacity and a common standard; MSC must run the roster and quality assurance.
B	Plan and management response mandatory; roster recommended, not required	More flexibility for offices; CCS evaluations stay uneven in approach and quality.
C	Plan and management response only; CCS provision referred back to MEC 2027	Smallest step; postpones country-led evaluation by a year.

Resources

One self-commissioned evaluation per office per biennium, funded within P3; MSC time for the roster and quality assurance.

The MEC is asked to

Adopt the evaluation and management-response requirements, with the roster mandatory for CCS evaluations (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts II.4 and X.2; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 3.2, 6.1 to 6.4, 10.1 and 11.4; Annex C, Domain 6 and Section C6; Annex G, Module 9. Domains: D6 Evaluation; D3 (Sub-dimension 3.2); D10 Accountability.

P6. Decision follow-up and Regional Office support standard

The policy in brief

Every decision records its evidence, root cause, owner, deadline and how completion will be verified; actions close only with verification; overdue actions are escalated; lessons are recorded and shared; Regional Office support requests are acknowledged within 5 working days and answered with an agreed plan within 20.

Why this policy

Decision-making is where performance is actually managed. The Framework's accountability loop requires decisions to be documented, turned into owned actions and verified against evidence, with a defined path upwards for issues an office cannot resolve: from the country review to the MEC, and from the MEC to the Regional Programme Meeting.

The 2026 decision log shows the loop is open at almost every point, and that Country Offices asking the Regional Office for help have no assurance of when or how they will receive it.

What the evidence shows

- **970** decisions logged in SAM1 2026 (800 unique); **none** records a root cause; **91** were overdue at export and **3** had been approved.
- **84** decisions need Regional Office support, from 19 Country Offices; 11 of them were already overdue, and no response standard exists.
- **13** decisions were escalated, to four different levels, with no defined pathway.
- The SAM1 Learning Hub holds **356** entries from 2026, of which **1** was flagged for regional sharing.

Scope

The decision logs and action trackers of the 47 Country Offices and the six Regional Office budget centres, and all support requested by Country Offices from the Regional Office.

The policy

1. **What a decision records.** As the Framework requires, each decision in the log records the evidence that prompted it, the decision, its owner by role and its deadline (Annex E; Annex G, Module 7). This policy adds three fields: the root cause, the expected effect and how completion will be verified. The SAM1 log already has a root-cause field; it is empty in all 970 entries. One decision may cover several P/S; duplicates are merged.
2. **Root cause for serious and recurring problems.** For decisions rated high or critical, and for problems that recur across several P/S, the root cause is established with a structured method such as the five whys, the technique Annex B, Section B5, applies to capability gaps.
3. **Owned actions.** Each decision gives rise to one or more actions in the action tracker, each with an owner and a deadline.
4. **Verification before closure.** An action is closed only when its completion and effect are confirmed against evidence by someone other than its owner, normally the MEAL focal point, following the verification protocol (Annex J). Until Annex J is issued, MSC issues a one-page verification protocol by 31 January 2027.
5. **Monthly follow-up.** Open and overdue actions are reviewed at every monthly WR-led review.
6. **Escalation path.** As the Framework sets out, issues an office cannot resolve go from the country review to the MEC, and from the MEC to the Regional Programme Meeting where warranted (Part XI.2). This policy adds two steps: an action overdue by more than 30 days, or a decision beyond the office's authority, first goes to the responsible Regional Office cluster for support; and between MEC sessions, the DPM handles escalated issues on the MEC's behalf and reports them at its next session.
7. **Regional Office support standard.** Country Offices record support requests in the decision log, with the Regional Office as the support required. The responsible cluster acknowledges each request within 5 working days, names a focal person and agrees an action plan with the office within 20 working days. A request that

cannot be met is answered with the reason and an alternative. MSC reports response times to the DPM each quarter and to the MEC each year.

8. **Learning from follow-through.** Each quarter, the WR-led review includes a short learning review of decisions that did or did not achieve their expected effect. Lessons are recorded in the learning repository (the Learning Hub; Annex G, Module 10); lessons of value to other offices are flagged for regional sharing and presented at the MEC (Annex C, Domain 9).
9. **Clean-up of the 2026 log.** By 31 January 2027, each office reviews its SAM1 2026 decisions: it merges duplicates, closes those completed with evidence and adds the root cause and owner to the rest.

Who does what

WHO Representative	Chairs the monthly review; accountable for the log and follow-through.
MEAL focal point	Maintains the log and tracker; verifies completion before closure.
Programme leads	Own and complete the actions.
Regional Office clusters	Meet the support standard; support offices on escalated actions.
MSC Unit, DPM and MEC	MSC monitors and reports; the DPM oversees the standard and handles escalated issues between MEC sessions; the MEC resolves escalated issues and refers systemic ones to the RPM.

Timeline

When	Milestone
1 Jan 2027	Decision standard and Regional Office support standard apply
31 Jan 2027	2026 decision logs cleaned in all offices
From Q1 2027	Quarterly learning review in every office; quarterly report on support response times to the DPM
SAM1 2027	First monitoring cycle under the standard
MEC 2027	First annual report on follow-through and support

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
Decisions recording a root cause, owner and deadline	Root cause 0 of 970	100% of new decisions
Decisions overdue	91 of 970 entries (9%) at export	Below 5%
Actions closed with verification evidence	Not yet measured	100%
Support requests acknowledged within 5 and planned within 20 working days	No standard	At least 90% for both

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**As proposed: decision standard, escalation path, learning review and Regional Office support standard**	Closes the loop at every level; clusters must staff the support standard.
B	Decision standard without escalation deadlines	Simpler to introduce, but overdue actions carry no consequence.
C	Regional Office support standard only	Answers the Country Offices' main request; leaves the country loop open.

Resources

Staff time in the clusters to meet the response standard; platform changes to the decision log and action tracker.

The MEC is asked to

Adopt the decision follow-up standard, the escalation path, the quarterly learning review and the Regional Office support standard (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts III.4, X.4 and XI.2; Annex B, Section B5; Annex C, Domains 8 and 9; Annex E; Annex G, Modules 7, 8 and 10; Annex J (not in this package). Domains: D8 Decision-making; D9 Learning; D10 Accountability.

P7. Burden- and equity-informed operational planning

The policy in brief

Each Country Office submits a two-page alignment profile with its 2028–2029 workplans, showing how its P/S, funding and workforce match national priorities, the burden of disease and the populations left behind; the Regional Office reviews it before approving the workplan.

Why this policy

The Framework asks leaders to direct resources "toward the Products and Services and populations where the evidence shows they will have the greatest effect", and requires analysis that is sex-disaggregated and equity-sensitive. Planning is the moment where that question is answered, or not.

The alignment method tested in the DRC in September 2026 sets what an office funds, staffs and delivers against national priorities and the burden of disease. It makes the choices visible, so that the office decides cause by cause what WHO takes on, what it leaves to partners and what must be financed.

What the evidence shows

- In the DRC, **91%** of 2026–2027 funding goes to epidemics, polio and immunization, which account for **9%** of the burden of disease; **49%** of DALYs fall in cause groups with no SAM1 P/S (DRC alignment analysis, September 2026).
- Across the 45 countries with GBD 2023 estimates, noncommunicable diseases account for **20% to 77%** of DALYs and injuries for **7% to 17%**: one regional template cannot fit every office.

Scope

The 47 Country Offices; the Regional Office clusters and the DPM in the review of workplans; the MSC Unit for the method and data.

The policy

1. **An alignment profile with the workplan.** With its 2028–2029 workplans, each office submits a two-page alignment profile covering national priorities (the CCS and the national health plan), the burden of disease (IHME GBD, with national data where available), WHO funding and workforce by area, delivery of its priority P/S, and the populations left behind.
2. **A position on each major cause.** For each major cause group, the profile records WHO's position (WHO leads, WHO supports partners, partners lead, or a gap to be financed) and the reason.
3. **Equity.** The profile includes sex-disaggregated and equity analysis and names the vulnerable populations considered (Annex C, Domain 12).
4. **Review before approval.** The Regional Office clusters and the DPM review the profile with the workplan and record their comments before approval. Differences between burden and funding are explained, not penalized: emergencies and the IHR mandate legitimately shift resources.
5. **A data pack for every office.** By 31 March 2027, MSC provides each office with the profile template and a data pack: burden of disease, SAM1 portfolio, funding and workforce. For Mauritius and Seychelles, absent from the GBD 2023 export used, the pack draws on national cause-of-death statistics and WHO Global Health Estimates.
6. **Use, not ranking.** Profiles inform dialogue with Member States and partners, resource mobilization and the next CCS. They are not used to compare or rank offices.

Who does what

WHO Representative	Owns the positioning decisions and presents them to the government and partners.

MEAL focal point and planning officer	Prepare the profile from the data pack.
Programme leads	Contribute the analysis for their areas.
MSC Unit	Issues the method, template and data packs; synthesizes the profiles for the MEC.
Regional Office clusters and DPM	Review profiles with workplans before approval.

Timeline

When	Milestone
31 Mar 2027	Template and data packs sent to all 47 offices
2027 planning cycle	Profiles prepared with the 2028–2029 workplans
Before approval	Regional Office review of each profile with its workplan
MEC 2027	Regional synthesis of the profiles

How compliance is measured

Indicator	Baseline	Target
Country Offices submitting a profile with their 2028–2029 workplans	1 tested (DRC)	47
Profiles reviewed before workplan approval	Not yet measured	47
Profiles recording a position on each major cause group	Not yet measured	47

Decision options

Option	What the MEC would adopt	Implications
A Recommended	**Profile mandatory for all Country Offices with the 2028–2029 workplans**	Every workplan is set against the burden; adds a review step to planning.
B	Mandatory for offices preparing a new CCS in 2027–2028; voluntary for others	Lighter, but most 2028–2029 workplans are approved without it.
C	Guidance and data packs only	No added requirement; alignment stays at each office's discretion.

Resources

MSC analysis to prepare 47 data packs; review time in the clusters during planning.

> **The MEC is asked to**
>
> Adopt the alignment profile as a requirement for all 2028–2029 workplans (option A).

Framework references: Framework Parts I.4, II.2 and X.3; Annex A, Sub-dimensions 2.1, 2.4, 7.3 and 12.1; Annex C, Domains 2 and 12; Annex F, Section F1. Domains: D2 Results architecture; D7 Analytics; D12 Gender and equity.

ANNEX

Consolidated timeline, 2027–2028

Milestones of the seven policies in date order, if all are adopted as recommended. The MEC 2027 report covers each policy.

When	Policy	Milestone
1 Jan 2027	**P2**	Standard applies to every assessment
1 Jan 2027	**P3**	Proposal rule applies
1 Jan 2027	**P6**	Decision standard and Regional Office support standard apply
From Q1 2027	**P6**	Quarterly learning review in every office; quarterly report on support response times to the DPM
Jan–Jun 2027	**P1**	Wave 1 Learning Labs, including the four pilot offices
31 Jan 2027	**P4**	Focal points designated with terms of reference in all 47 offices; cluster focal points named
31 Jan 2027	**P6**	2026 decision logs cleaned in all offices
31 Mar 2027	**P1**	Annex C self-assessment completed by all 47 Country Offices
31 Mar 2027	**P2**	Evidence guidance with examples by type of P/S; evidence and consistency fields on the platform
31 Mar 2027	**P3**	MEAL marker applied; current MEAL allocation recorded for every budget centre
31 Mar 2027	**P5**	Templates for the evaluation plan and management response issued; interim registry opened by MSC
31 Mar 2027	**P7**	Template and data packs sent to all 47 offices
From Q2 2027	**P4**	Academy core track in cohorts aligned with the Learning Lab waves
30 Jun 2027	**P5**	Evaluation plans for 2027 recorded; regional roster established
1 Jul 2027	**P5**	Country-led rule applies to new CCS evaluations
Jul–Dec 2027	**P1**	Wave 2 Learning Labs; first heat map at MEC 2027
SAM1 2027	**P2**	First cycle with pre-filled financial figures and the verification sample
SAM1 2027	**P3**	First report of MEAL allocation and expenditure by budget centre
SAM1 2027	**P6**	First monitoring cycle under the standard
2027 planning cycle	**P3**	MEAL planned at 3% or more in all 2028–2029 workplans
2027 planning cycle	**P5**	Costed 2028–2029 evaluation plans in the workplans
2027 planning cycle	**P7**	Profiles prepared with the 2028–2029 workplans
Before approval	**P7**	Regional Office review of each profile with its workplan
MEC 2027	**P2**	First report on verification results
MEC 2027	**P3**	Regional MEAL financing report
MEC 2027	**P5**	First report on evaluations and management responses
MEC 2027	**P6**	First annual report on follow-through and support
MEC 2027	**P7**	Regional synthesis of the profiles
31 Dec 2027	**P2**	Every office has run one data quality assessment
31 Dec 2027	**P4**	Competencies of all focal points verified
Jan–Jun 2028	**P1**	Wave 3 Learning Labs; all baselines validated
31 Mar 2028	**P4**	All focal points certified

When	Policy	Milestone
31 Aug 2028	**P1**	All 47 development plans endorsed and in the workplans

ANNEX

Parameters proposed by these policies

The Framework leaves these parameters open. Each is a proposal the MEC can amend when it adopts the policy, without reopening the rest of the text.

Policy	Parameter	Proposed value
General	Meaning of persistent low maturity	No progress across two consecutive annual reviews; management discussion held by the DPM
General	Adjusted sequence in emergencies	Agreed by the DPM; the floor is not lowered
General	Platform	The platform used for SAM1 2026 serves as the first phase until Annex G is implemented
P1	Annex C self-assessment	By 31 March 2027
P1	Learning Lab waves	January–June 2027, July–December 2027, January–June 2028
P1	Development plan	Within eight weeks of the validated baseline; integrated at workplan preparation (wave 1) or first revision of 2028 (waves 2 and 3)
P2	Evidence rule	Unverified “completed” and “strong contribution” ratings are not counted in regional reports
P2	Verification sample	10% of these ratings each cycle, every budget centre at least once a year
P2	Data quality assessment	At least once a year on decision-critical indicators
P3	Interim denominator until Annex I	Financed workplan budget, all funding sources
P3	MEAL marker and proposal rule	Marker by 31 March 2027; proposals at 3% or more from 1 January 2027
P4	Focal point designation	By 31 January 2027, with at least 50% protected time; interim within 30 days of a departure
P4	Certification	By 31 March 2028
P5	Evaluation plans and roster	By 30 June 2027; country-led CCS evaluations from 1 July 2027
P5	Management response	Within 60 days of the final report
P6	Added decision fields	Root cause, expected effect and verification method; verification by someone other than the owner
P6	Escalation additions	To the Regional Office cluster after 30 days overdue; the DPM acts for the MEC between sessions
P6	Regional Office support standard	Acknowledged within 5 working days; action plan within 20
P6	Learning review and log clean-up	Quarterly learning review; 2026 decision log cleaned by 31 January 2027
P7	Alignment profile	Two pages with the 2028–2029 workplans; data packs by 31 March 2027